artistic production, wherein "artists … continued to have access to the highest quality materials [and] worked with iconographic themes related to religious practices in contemporaneous Central Asia".[40]

The new rulers and their loyal vassals and/or kinsmen were all pragmatically ecumenical: in order to reconfigure commerce to their advantage, they emphasized the north–south routes through Bamiyan, largely displacing the east–west "trans-Gandhara" corridor as the primary access connecting India and Central Asia. Already an established Buddhist site, they might have further enforced passage through Bamiyan by adopting it as the *dynastic* center of the newly ascendant Khaganate, while its *political* center or regional capital was probably Qunduz.[41] A dynastic imprimatur would permit the Western Turks to profit greatly from Bamiyan's traffic of people (including merchants), goods, and ideas on the north–south trajectory through their territories.[42] Inadvertently or not, the Khaganate also encouraged – perhaps patronized – the institutions and practices of Buddhism already established in the area, even if these lay outside the Western Turks' ritual associations (cf. Chapter 2 and below).

The five contiguous valleys comprising the core area around Bamiyan (Figure 3.8) appear to have been primarily dedicated to Buddhist monasticism and dotted with artificial and natural grottoes, all domiciling Buddhist rituals and monastic residences.[43] However, political and administrative control of the area, necessarily monitoring access along the various routes in and out of the basin, was concentrated in hilltop complexes such as the well documented Shahr-i Zuhak (Figures 3.9–3.11) and the spectacular, recently re-surveyed Shahr-i Ghulghula (Figures I.22, 3.12, 3.13). Indeed, Bamiyan and its immediate areas to the north and west are replete with remains of rambling complexes large and small, usually atop high promontories, seeming to form a geographic, climatic, and even architectural continuum with the Shansabanis' home region of Ghur immediately to the west and south (cf. Chapter 2).[44] The mid-twentieth-century surveys by Marc Le Berre (published in the 1970s–1980s); subsequent surveys, documentation and analysis by Z. Tarzi (esp. 1977, 2007); and, finally, excavations by P. Baker and R. Allchin (1991) at Shahr-i Zuhak have been invaluable for obtaining a glimpse of the Bamiyan basin's non-religious architecture. This corpus, together with the Buddhist monasteries and other religious sites,[45] enables an overall apprehension of the region's pre-Islamic architectural culture, its continuation into later periods, and its commonality with building practices in other regions of Afghanistan.

Shahr-i Zuhak (Figures 3.9–3.11) as the better-studied hilltop site in the Bamiyan basin serves as an example of the area's architectural developments. Archaeologically, the initial foundation of Shahr-i Zuhak and nearby hilltop complexes has been attributed to the Sasanian–Hephthalite period, up to *c.* 500 CE, though phases of occupation at most Bamiyan sites continued for several centuries afterward. With the rise of the Western